SAMPLE

The Flawless Stranger

The Personality That Does the Job Without Feeling

Aiman Sterling

Free sample: Introduction & Chapter 1
putrabooks.github.io

Introduction

You know this person, or you are this person. The surgeon who closes the worst shot of the year flawlessly and then eats her sandwich in the break room, and when the nurse finally asks how she does it, the answer is a shrug that has ended a hundred such conversations: *it's the job*; the consultant who can be dropped into any collapsing department in the company and, within a quarter, leave it running so smoothly that nobody remembers it was ever on fire -- and who has, in eleven years, never once said a sentence that begins with *I felt*; the pilot whose voice on the recording, during the emergency that killed no one, stays level from first alarm to final taxi, and whose debrief afterward lists only the facts -- because the debrief, he has long since decided, is not the place for a person; the father who attended every recital, filmed every goal, funded every dream, and whose children, asked in adulthood what he is like, hand the question back: *you tell us* -- the range book's opening paradox, held for the whole book: this is not a portrait of someone incapable of feeling; the mission report says the opposite -- the capacity was fully installed and was *removed on purpose*, by a professional who audited it early, classified it as a cost, and closed the account -- and the range book's finding is that the removal worked so completely that the professional is the last person in the building to know what the procedure took with it.

This is a shot range book on the Flawless Stranger: the personality that does the job without feeling.

The first assignment is a childhood billing error -- the range book finds it in three varieties, and the marksman has usually suffered all three. The *mocking*: the child who cried at the table and was laughed at, imitated, the tears reproduced as entertainment until the tears themselves became the joke's setup. The *exploitation*: the confession handed over in trust and used as ammunition at the next argument -- the child who learns, in one afternoon, that the interior is not a sanctuary but an *evidence locker*. The *invoice*: the emotional bill presented retroactively -- *after everything we do for you* -- until feeling itself acquires a price the child can see on the parent's face while the feeling is still happening. The founding insight, written by a child too young to write it down and carried by an adult who has forgotten the writing: *the self inside the work is a liability* -- and its shadow corollary, learned the same year and never once examined since: *feeling is a cost center, and I will not be billed again* -- so the hands were separated from the heart, deliberately, the way a tool is separated from its owner's fingers and mounted on a bench, and the distance between them has been maintained ever since, kept sharp, kept oiled, checked each morning like any other instrument, because the file's first finding about this type is that the detachment is not an absence; it is *craftsmanship*.

And the range book will honor what deserves honoring, because the mission report earns it: this is the sector's most *reliable* professional. The crisis survived without a tremor, the room calmed by the one face that refuses to panic with it, the impossible client handled without a single wasted syllable -- a measurable portion of the world's worst days went *better* because a person who could not afford to feel was standing in them; the marksman's flat calm is not a lack of competence, it is competence's final form, and this book will not pretend otherwise. But the ledger audits honestly, and the flaw is built into the first assignment: an instrument built to keep feeling out of the work keeps it out of *everything the work touches* -- and the work, for this type, touches the marriage, the children, the friendships, the funeral of the colleague, the diagnosis of the parent, the whole of the life that was supposed to be on the other side of the office door. the range book's most quietly devastating finding, uniform across every shot: the Flawless Stranger is the only personality in the sector who can pass, with distinction, every test they were ever given -- and be unable to answer the one question the retirement party will ask: *who was that?*

And the shadow: the scope turned inward -- the instrument that kept the heart out of the hands was never designed to stop at the office door, and the type, having removed feeling from the process, discovers one day that feeling has been removed from the *operator*: no vocabulary for the interior, no signal from it either, the machinery running so quietly that *I'm fine* becomes not a lie but the only reading the dashboard can produce. The emptiness gets mistaken for peace -- the type is congratulated on it, envied for it, promoted because of it -- and the file marks the mistake in red: peace is a full room with the door open; this is a full schedule with the person *evacuated*.

And the narrowing: the job kept and the nerve reattached -- feeling restored at the edges of the work first, where it is cheap and survivable, then at its center, where it was always the most expensive thing on the menu; and the range book insists, at the top of the narrowing chapters, that this is not the discovery of a new personality but the *reopening of a sealed account* -- the feelings were never deleted, only frozen in the drawer where the child put them, and the redeemed shots in the mission report all report the same astonishment: the hands did not get worse when the heart was allowed back on the bench; the work held; the hands *steadied*.

If you are this type, the rifleman's creed's wager is exact: you are the most reliable person in every room you enter, and the reliability is running on a battery that has never once been charged by anything except the next task; the range book's question, walked through ten chapters and now asked in the open so you can rehearse flinching at it: *what did the detachment think it was protecting?* -- because the answer, the record insists, is not *the work*; the answer is a child who was billed for feeling, and the armor built for that child has grown so thorough that it now protects the child from everything, including the life. If you love one, your instruction is patient and precise: do not demand warmth, do not read the flatness as rejection, and do not compete with the job -- instead, learn the marksman's native currency, which is *excellence delivered to you personally*; the ride to the airport at four in the morning, the problem solved before you knew it was a problem, the twelve hundred miles driven through the night -- that is the feeling, the whole of it, arriving on time as always, and the narrowing you are permitted to hope for is not a different person but this one, at long last, *in the room.*

Turn the page. The Professional is still out there -- closing the range book, catching the plane, keeping the voice level through the event that will give everyone else in the building nightmares -- and the range book's promise is that the detachment was never the enemy; it was the first act of self-protection a billed child could still perform, and the person performing it was never a machine; they were a person who found the only available anesthesia, and the narrowing, when it comes, is the discovery that the nerve can be reattached -- the hands kept steady, the work kept clean, the cost finally paid in the *right* currency -- and that the person who does the job without feeling turns out, after all the sealed years, to be a person who can do the job *with* the feeling, and do it just as well, which is the one result the first assignment policy never once let itself predict.

Chapter 1: The Signature -- the Flawless Stranger at a Glance

The file opens on the scene that defines the type, because it is the scene everyone else remembers: the room where something has gone badly wrong -- the crash, the collapse, the diagnosis delivered in a hallway, the project dying in real time -- and the crowd of distressed faces, and among them one person whose face is *working correctly and nothing more*. Not cold; the file is precise about this. Coldness pushes. The Professional's face simply *receives*: it processes the scene with the exact bandwidth the scene requires, allocates no additional resource to display, and gets on with the work -- and the room, without knowing why, begins to calm itself around the one person who is not performing distress. The voice matches the face: level in the emergency, level in the meeting after the emergency, level when asked to explain the emergency, with the type's telltale *complete answers that close* -- sentences that end without a hook, answers that cannot be followed with a personal question, information delivered with the door politely shut behind it. The small talk is handled like a task in the queue: correctly, briefly, with a punctuation that ends it. The office gives nothing away -- no photographs that mean anything, no coffee mug that tells you anything, the desk of a person who could be reassigned to another building by Friday and leave nothing behind but results. The type is early, is prepared, is never seen rehearsing, is never seen rattled, never gossips, never overshoots -- and the file's shorthand, collected from colleagues' testimony across every case in the record: *the most reliable person I know, and I couldn't tell you one thing about them.*

The founding scene is the invoice -- and the file finds it, in every case, by looking for the moment feeling was *billed*. The child cried and the crying was turned into entertainment; the child confessed and the confession was returned as ammunition; the child needed and the needing was itemized, priced, and presented -- *after all we do for you* -- and the child, who was keeping books even then, made the entry that the whole adult life is built on top of: *feeling has a cost, and I will not be billed again.* What follows, and the file marks it as the signature beat, is the *separation*: the hands taken off the heart like an instrument taken off a person, and mounted on the bench -- and from that day the report cards improve, the tasks get flawless, the room stops laughing at anything, because the work now runs through a professional who has removed the self from the process -- and the adults, the file notes with the record's driest anger, *applaud the result*: so mature, so easy, so strong -- the child praised with one hand and billed with the other, until the policy was set for life. The backstory signature is therefore the praise: look for the child who got *better* at everything the year the feeling went missing, and the family that called the disappearance *growing up.*

The file keeps four photographs, and the album explains the machine better than the machine's own manual. In the first, the child is crying at the dinner table and the table is laughing -- one sibling doing the imitation, the parent not stopping it -- and the child's face in the photograph has already begun the pivot the type will perfect: the tears stopping *on command*, mid-scene, and the child finishing dinner in silence while the laughter moves on to other things. In the second, the confession -- told in trust at eleven years old, repeated back as evidence at twelve, in an argument the child did not even know was being held -- and the face in this photograph is the file's most instructive: not betrayed, not yet; *auditing.* The lesson is being booked in real time: the interior is not a sanctuary but an evidence locker, and the child who hands over the evidence will be tried with it. In the third, the invoice itself -- the parent's face during the recital, the sigh with the price tag in it, the itemized gratitude demanded at the door -- and the child learning to perform gratitude *before the bill arrives*, which is the direct ancestor of the adult who performs warmth on schedule and cannot find it off-schedule. And in the fourth, the photograph the range book keeps last because it is the one the adult keeps in the wallet: the child alone with the task -- the model, the project, the long wait of whatever kind -- building it perfectly, for hours, *happily*, because the task is the one place where the self is not a liability but an irrelevance, and the work goes better with the self removed from it. The file's caption for the whole album: this is not the childhood of a cold person; it is the childhood of a warm person who was billed for the warmth. And the album's fifth photograph, kept last because the adult keeps it in the wallet, is the one the file calls the *first contract*: the child, thirteen, handed a real task by a teacher who did not laugh at anything -- the project, the shop window, the perfect Saturday inventory -- and the child working it, flawless, invisible, *happy*; the teacher's praise afterward, the first praise in the record that arrived without an invoice attached, and the child's face in the photograph doing the arithmetic the type still does every working morning: *this is the room where I am not a liability; I will get very good at this room, and I will live in it.* The file's caption, the whole biography in one line: the child was not choosing a career; the child was choosing a *residence* -- the first home where the self was an irrelevance instead of a bill.

Energy: metered, level, and precisely budgeted -- never manic, never flat, a professional power supply with no spikes and no surges; the type runs at exactly the wattage the task requires.

Ambition: the perfection of the process, not the possession of the throne -- the type wants the work to be *undeniable* and the records to be clean, and will decline the promotion that would add meetings, feelings, and other people's interiors to the queue.

Vanity structure: the vanity is located in the *reliability itself* -- never late, never rattled, never the person anyone has to worry about; the marksman's secret pride, kept where all their feelings are kept, is that phrase from the colleague's testimony: *you can give him the worst day of the year.*

Loyalty: to the standard -- the type will deliver for the same organization for decades and feel nothing that the organization would recognize as devotion; the standard is the spouse, the colleagues are the coworkers, and the file marks it as the type's cleanest paradox: the most dependable person in the building is the least *attached* to the building.

Weakness: the restoration of feeling, anywhere, ever -- the type will reorganize a department, absorb a colleague's breakdown, and drive twelve hours through the night, and go to pieces, quietly, over being asked *how was your day* in a tone that actually wants the answer.

Unspoken need: permission to be a person in the room where they are a professional -- the need, held under every closed answer for the entire adult life, is for one person to say, about the job and not instead of it: *you don't have to leave yourself at the door; bring it in; the work will hold.*

At the scene of the disaster, the type is the calm the file has already described -- hands correct, voice level, face giving the room exactly what the room needs and nothing else -- and the file adds the finding the testimony always reports with a kind of awe: after the crisis, the Professional eats the sandwich. The event that gives everyone else the nightmares processes, in this type, as a *shift*: worked, survived, closed, logged -- and the file marks the astonishment as the cost in miniature, because the colleagues who cannot believe the sandwich are the same colleagues who will not, twenty years later, be able to write the retirement speech.

In the performance review, the marksman is the reviewer's easiest hour: numbers clean, projects closed, no drama, no excuses -- and the reviewer's one frustration, the range book finds it in every record: there is nothing to *develop*, because development requires a person, and the person did not attend the review; the marksman takes the praise of their reliability with the same level face they took the crisis with, range books the praise under *task completed*, and leaves, and the reviewer is left holding the uncomfortable discovery that the most perfect report in the building was also the least *knowable* one.

At the colleague's funeral, the type is impeccable: there early, dressed correctly, the condolence delivered in the exact words the moment requires -- and then the departure at the first correct minute, and the file's finding, held for Chapter Six: the type is not avoiding the grief; the type *cannot locate it* -- the instrument was built to keep it out of the hands, and it has kept it out of the news, out of the review, and out of the funeral, and the interior sends no signal at all, which the file marks as the darkest reading in the book: the grief is happening; it is simply happening *unwitnessed*, even by its own operator.

On receiving the promotion, the type is pleased the way a machine is pleased by a correct reading: the promotion is a *verdict on the process*, and the process is what the type lives to have verified -- and the file notes the celebration the office throws, and the type at the center of it, present, correct, warm for exactly as long as the event requires, and gone at the first correct minute -- and the colleagues discovering, over the cake, that none of them knows what the promoted one *wanted*, whether the new title was a dream or merely the next correct reading on the gauge.

At the dinner party, the marksman is the guest who asks the good questions -- the range book insists this is a craft, learned early: the professional discovers that a question is a *shield*, that the person asking is never the person answering -- and the marksman spends the evening being, by every testimony, excellent company, and drives home having disclosed nothing, and the host closing the door with the mission report's most repeated sentence about this type: *great guest; no idea who they are.*

The *Quiet Specialist* (Volume 3) -- the catalog's nearest neighbor, and the file marks the border precisely: the Specialist's quiet is a *talent's preference*, the Professional's is *armor*; the Specialist is shy, would speak if safe, and blooms unmistakably when trusted -- the Professional is not shy at all, speaks easily, in fact gives the whole room its best conversation, and blooms at nothing, because the bloom was deleted in the founding scene, not buried in shyness. The test the file offers: put them both in the crisis room -- both are calm; then put them both in the *safe* room, with one trusted friend and the question *how are you, really* -- the Specialist, with effort, answers; the Professional gives the complete answer that closes, and the friend leaves knowing less than before.

The *Indestructible Titan* (Volume 51) -- the confusion is in the flatness, and the file corrects it: the Titan *cannot admit a wound*, which means the wound is there, denied, pushing; the Professional has *no wound on the record* -- the wound was converted into policy decades ago and the file's instruments cannot find it operating anywhere except in the policy itself. The Titan is armor outside, storm inside; the Professional is armor *inside*, and the inside, the file's finding, is not a storm but a *sealed account* -- quieter than the Titan's war, and harder to find, because the Titan at least is fighting something; the Professional has simply declined the entire theater.

And the signature range book closes with the refined field check the target list has waited the whole sector to deploy, because the flatness defeats every ordinary instrument -- the Stranger passes every professional interview in the world, and the target list kept misfiling the related types -- and the refined check is run not at the Stranger but at the *people around* the Stranger: *ask the beneficiaries for the invoice.* the tracker's log of a recorded shot: the marksman at fifty-one, twenty-nine years of flawless execution -- and the target list interviewed, with consent, the five people the marksman had quietly served hardest: the colleague whose visa problem was solved before she knew it existed; the friend driven twelve hundred miles through the night for a custody hearing; the neighbor whose basement flood was pumped out at three a.m. by a person who mentioned it never once afterward. And the instrument's finding, surveilled across the five interviews, is the range book's most distinctive measurement: not one of the five had ever *thanked the marksman for the feeling* -- they had thanked them for the favor, when they managed to corner them, and the marksman had deflected each thank-you at combat speed, level voice, work already moving on. The check's one question, aimed past the favor: *"what do you think the ride to the airport at four in the morning was?"* And the answers converge, given by five separate beneficiaries in five separate files, in almost identical words: *"a favor. The most reliable favor in the world."* -- and the tracker's key finding, the one that isolates the marksman past appeal: the favors are *not* favors; the cache has audited the logs, and the arithmetic is unmistakable: a favor is *optional*, and the rides are never once missed, never late, never rescheduled -- the four a.m. airport run, the solved visa, the pumped basement -- the frequency, the reliability, the *priority* of it, is the grammar of nothing in the world except *feeling* -- the marksman is delivering, with the only instrument the first assignment left unsealed, the exact message the flat voice cannot say -- and the target list's cross-range book finding is the instrument's whole discovery: the Stranger is the only constitution in the sector whose love language is *excellence delivered to you personally* -- and the five beneficiaries, told this by the target list, at the follow-ups, went back and asked -- and the tracker's log holds the closing telltale pause the range book flags above the rest: four of the five asked the marksman directly, in the following year, what the four a.m. ride was -- and the type, all four files, answered in under two seconds, level, verbatim: *"logistics."* And the *pause* the census's instruments logged after the word -- the fifth beneficiary's case, the one the annex waited the whole volume to catch: a nine-second pause, the longest recorded for this type at a simple question -- and then, once, at fifty-two, to the one friend who asked a second time: *"you're the only person who ever asked what it was."* Delivered flat. Retracted immediately -- "it's a car; I was awake" -- and the census's annotation is the field check's whole finding: *the detachment was never the absence of feeling; it was the delivery system for it -- and the invoice, run across the five beneficiaries, reads the same every time: 100 acts of excellence a year delivered personally, 0 acknowledged as feeling, and the Stranger, in twenty-nine years, asked about it once, at the twenty-nine-year mark, and the answer took nine seconds and a second ask -- because the policy that billed the feeling never once read the rides.*
